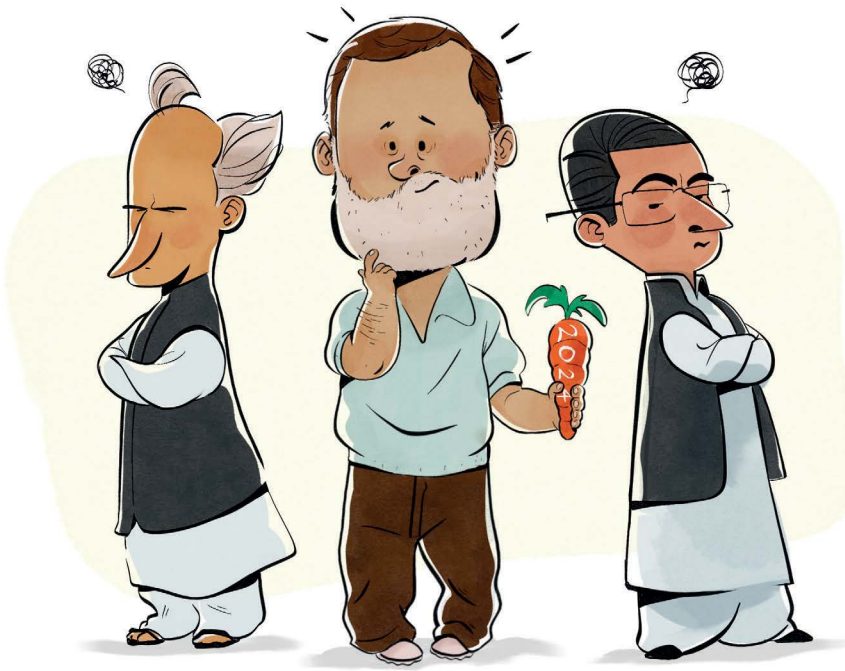


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE BAIT OF 2024

How did the Congress get Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot and his former deputy and bête noire Sachin Pilot to bury the hatchet? The answer lies in the Congress win in Karnataka and the subsequent power-sharing between CM Siddaramaiah and his deputy D.K. Shivakumar. It gave Rahul Gandhi the excuse to tell Pilot that even Shivakumar sacrificed his CM ambition for now as the Congress is expected to do well in the 2024 general election. The high command will then be able to accommodate the incumbent CMs in Delhi's power corridors and leave the states for their younger rivals. That Pilot has lost interest in the CM chair five months ahead of the assembly polls also made it easy for Congress negotiators. Now to see if the 2024 election follows the Congress script.

Mixed Signals

First they rebelled and split the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). Now Maharashtra deputy chief minister **Ajit Pawar** and his men have met party patriarch **Sharad Pawar** twice in two days. Ajit also met aunt Pratibha after she went through a medical procedure. What's going on? The rebels say they appealed to Pawar Sr to keep the party united. However, the latter's loyalists see it as an attempt to sow confusion about Pawar Sr's intent to stay with the Opposition alliance. They say there is no question of him joining hands with the BJP.



ANI

TITLE TATTLE



'Banglaye Didir Officer', or Didi's Officers. That is what Block Development Officers (BDOs) are being called in West Bengal. But this is no epithet. Rather this is the designation that the people of Bengal have bestowed upon the BDOs, given all the help they extended, allegedly to favour Chief Minister **Mamata Banerjee**'s party Trinamool Congress in the recent panchayat polls. Results at several polling stations were withheld for electoral and counting malpractices. A few BDOs are also facing allegations of flexing their muscle. Is that what they call winning by hook or by crook?



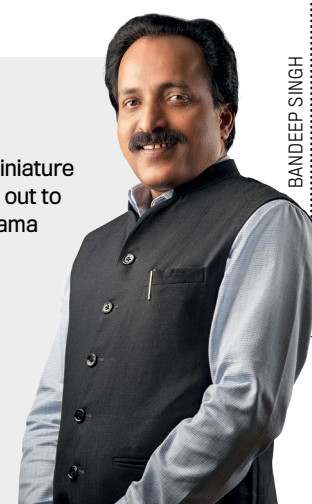
New Math, Old Player

An old warhorse is playing key interlocutor in the eclectic group of Opposition parties coming together ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Former Gujarat chief minister **Shankersinh Vaghela** has been meeting top leaders of regional parties, such as **Akhilesh Yadav**, Uddhav Thackeray, K. Chandrashekar Rao, Naveen Patnaik and Lalu Prasad, in the past two months. The veteran aims to keep working the communication channels through the rough and tumble of elections, from seat-sharing negotiations to post-poll settlements.

Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Romita Datta, Dhaval Kulkarni and Amarnath K. Menon

FUELLED BY DIVINITY

Before every launch in space, ISRO top honchos, armed with a miniature model of the spacecraft to be placed at the feet of the deity, set out to pray at the richest Hindu shrine atop Tirumala and at the Sri Chengalama Parameswarini temple in Sullurpeta, 22 km away from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota. ISRO chairman **S. Somanath** and others did the same on July 13, a day before the Chandrayaan-3 lift-off. The visits are repeated after the launch, even if it ends in failure. Temple runs weren't a thing when the man after whom the launch centre is named was ISRO chief. Now, along with cryogenic forces, a bit of divine thrust also helps.



BANDEEP SINGH